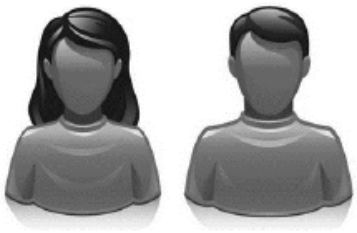
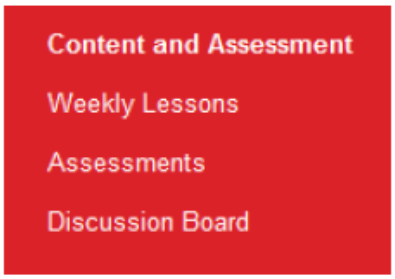
Working with Collaboration Tools



Blackboard's interactive tools provide the opportunity for faculty to build rich assignments and offer another means for evaluating students. With these essential tools, faculty can provide students with constructive comments, guidance and assessment. The various tools can be used alone or in combination depending on the faculty's goals. Faculty and students can personalize their experience with these tools by uploading their photo or digital image. For more information on how to do this, click on the link to open Upload your Avatar to Blackboard.

The following information is intended to help you create collaboration links on the course menu and to help you decide which tools best suits your needs.

Adding Collaboration Tools to the Course Menu



You can add a collaboration link to the course menu for one-click access to any collaboration tool by following these simple steps:

1. Make sure the **Edit Mode** is ON.
2. Point to the **+ sign** above the course menu.
3. From the **Add Menu** Item drop-down list > **Tool Link**
4. Type a name for the link (e.g., Discussion Board)
5. **Important:** From the Type drop-down list, click on the collaboration tool you wish to add (e.g., Discussion Board, Wiki, Blog, etc.).
6. Select the **Available to Users** check box > Submit.

The new tool link will appear last in the course menu list. Press and drag the arrows icon to move the link into a new position. You can rename, delete, or hide the link from students by accessing the link's contextual menu .

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Select the Tools that Best Meet your Needs

Each of the four interactive tools can serve distinct purposes. You can use one or all of them in your course, and they can work well in combination. The following information and examples are intended to help you decide which tool to use.

Journals: Students can express their thoughts, questions and concerns to you privately. Students can record observations, identify areas for help, develop a plan for improvement, set goals, evaluate their educational journeys, submit prewriting for a graded assignment for guidance and feedback, etc.

Discussions: Students can express their ideas, gathering feedback and help with refining their opinions and plans. Students can post ideas for projects and ask for feedback. They can brainstorm ideas for a wiki project, etc.

Blogs: Students can interpret what they learned, submit the final draft of a written, graded assignment, analyze a topic, adding information over several weeks, provide commentary on a subject, incorporate rich media into their post, etc.

Wikis: This tool is used to create content collaboratively. Students can contribute within the whole class or they can be divided into groups. Everyone may edit and organize the content. Wikis can be used to work on class summaries, resources repository (links, pictures, articles, media files, etc.), group project presentations, final test reviews, etc.

Chat: The chat tool allows everyone to interact using a text-based chat. Use the chat tool when real-time discussion is required. Most students are comfortable with using some form of chat.

Discussion + Wikis: On the discussion board, students post their ideas for a course wiki assignment. As students present their ideas and posts develop, they narrow the topic and divide the work before they transition to the wiki.

Journal + Blogs: Assign a graded blog requiring students to fully explore a topic, adding entries as the term progresses. However, the topic planning begins in the journals tool where you offer guidance and support. Help students clarify the main points and ask for writing samples before they post their ideas for the entire class to read and comment on.

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Discussion + Blogs: Ask students to post an internet source on the discussion board that expands on the most recent lecture. Next, in their blogs, students can select a source and synthesize that information with the course material, extending their understanding beyond the classroom. Ask all students to provide comments for at least two classmates' entries that include potential test questions.

For Blackboard Assistance, please Contact your eLearning Specialists:

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- Elizabeth Pero (Kingston), 613-544 5400 X 1963 or epero@sl.on.ca
  School for Contemporary Teaching and Learning

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